

Dilzafer Singh

Idea: AI Workspace for Students (Socratiq)

1. Product overview

Socratiq is an AI-native educational platform designed specifically for academic environments, providing a controlled and pedagogically-sound interface for students to leverage generative AI while maintaining academic integrity. Unlike general-purpose AI tools, Socratiq employs carefully crafted system prompts that guide students through the learning process using Socratic questioning, progressive skill development, and transparent usage monitoring for educators.

2. Competitors / differentiation

Existing similar services: ChatGPT Study Mode is the closest competitor, offering AI assistance tailored for students with features like simplified explanations and step-by-step problem solving. However, it operates as a feature within a broader platform rather than a comprehensive educational solution. This is also important when thinking about this product from a sales perspective because, when a large model company like OpenAI tries to sell their product to an educational institution like Harvard, they aren't just selling "study mode" but the entire platform, one that clearly has no safeguards to prevent students from abusing the platform. Khanmigo by Khan Academy provides AI tutoring with some educational safeguards, but has less monitoring capabilities. Khanmigo is also catered for younger students. Grammarly offers writing assistance with educational accounts, but it again doesn't have any safe-guards in place to ensure a student isn't just using the platform to entirely rewrite their essays for example. Turnitin, GPTZero, and other tools' LLM detection tools approach the problem from the opposite angle, focusing on catching AI misuse rather than enabling proper use. As an aside, these detection models have also been found to not be accurate.

3. Why now?

The convergence of several factors has created a unique opportunity for Socratiq. First, the widespread availability of powerful language models since 2022 has made AI assistance inevitable in education - students will use these tools regardless of policies. Second, the educational community's fragmented response has created a vacuum for purposeful solutions. While some institutions ban AI outright and others embrace it without guidelines, there's a clear need for a middle path that harnesses AI's benefits while preserving learning outcomes. Even at Harvard, beyond a couple of vague guidelines, AI-policy is not even standardized department-wide; these policies are professor by professor. Further, the technological maturity of prompt/context engineering now allows for sophisticated pedagogical approaches to be embedded directly into AI interactions. Many APIs enable granular usage tracking and customizable guardrails that weren't feasible even two years ago. Additionally, the growing body of research on AI in education provides evidence-based approaches for implementation, while increasing pressure on educational institutions to prepare students for an AI-integrated workforce creates urgency for adoption.

Potential stakeholders:

- Students (primary users) seek efficient learning tools that help them understand complex concepts, improve their work quality, and manage academic workload. They value convenience, clarity, and tools that genuinely enhance their understanding rather than simply providing answers. Their primary motivation is academic success balanced with authentic learning. They're likely to engage deeply with tools that respect their intelligence while providing meaningful support, but may attempt to circumvent restrictions they perceive as arbitrary.
- Teachers / professors / educators want to maintain academic integrity while preparing students for a technology-enhanced future. They value transparency in student AI use, tools that complement rather than replace teaching, and evidence of genuine student learning. Their motivations include fostering critical thinking, ensuring fair assessment, and adapting to technological change without compromising educational standards. They need confidence that AI tools enhance rather than shortcut the learning process.
- Educational institutions (customers)
Schools and universities need solutions that align with academic policies, provide accountability, and demonstrate educational value. They value compliance, measurable learning outcomes, and tools that enhance their reputation as forward-thinking institutions. Cost-effectiveness and ease of implementation are crucial motivators, along with the ability to maintain consistent standards across departments.
- Parents/guardians want assurance that technology supports rather than hinders their children's education. They value tools that promote genuine learning, provide visibility into student progress, and prepare students for future careers. Their concerns center on screen time, academic honesty, and ensuring their investment in education yields real knowledge and skills.
- Regulatory bodies. Educational regulators and accreditation bodies focus on maintaining educational standards and ensuring equitable access to learning tools. They value transparency, data privacy compliance (especially regarding minor students), and evidence-based educational practices. They're motivated by protecting student welfare and maintaining the credibility of educational credentials.
- Investors in EdTech seek scalable solutions with clear monetization paths and strong adoption potential. They value defensible differentiation, recurring revenue models, and alignment with educational trends. The massive education market and the inevitability of AI integration make this an attractive investment opportunity if execution risks can be managed.
- Employees / Socratiq team, including developers, educational consultants, and support staff, seek to make meaningful impact in education while building a sustainable business. They value working on ethically sound products that genuinely benefit users, along with professional growth opportunities in the emerging field of educational AI
- LLM providers like OpenAI, Anthropic, or Google (as technology partners rather than competitors) have interest in educational applications of their models that demonstrate responsible use. They value partnerships that expand their reach into education markets while addressing concerns about AI misuse in academic settings

User journey - an undergrad writing a research paper

discovery → research → writing → revision → submission

Sarah, a sophomore psychology major, begins her journey with Socratiq when assigned a 15-page research paper on cognitive behavioral therapy applications. Initially approaching the platform hoping for quick answers, she discovers that Socratiq's Socratic method requires her to engage deeply with her topic. In the [discovery phase](#), Sarah logs in through her university portal, immediately establishing the accountability framework. Unlike ChatGPT, she cannot simply request a full essay. Instead, Socratiq prompts her to articulate her research question, guiding her through refining "write about CBT" into a focused thesis about CBT's effectiveness for teenage anxiety disorders. The platform suggests relevant academic databases and helps her evaluate source credibility, teaching information literacy skills her professor values while addressing the institution's concern about proper citations.

During the [research phase](#), Sarah experiences creative tension between her desire for efficiency and Socratiq's pedagogical approach. When she pastes a complex journal article and asks for a summary, instead of providing one immediately, Socratiq guides her through identifying key arguments, methodology, and limitations. This takes longer than she'd like, creating friction with her time management needs, but she realizes she actually understands the material rather than just collecting quotes. Her professor can see she's engaged with twelve sources over three sessions, addressing their need for process visibility.

In the [writing phase](#), Sarah drafts a paragraph and requests improvement. Rather than rewriting it, Socratiq identifies areas for development: "Your topic sentence makes a claim about effectiveness. What evidence from your sources supports this?" It suggests specific rhetorical strategies and helps her recognize passive voice, but requires her to implement changes herself. This respects her authorship while providing substantive support, though she occasionally feels frustrated that it won't just "fix" her writing.

In the [revision phase](#), Socratiq helps Sarah identify logical gaps and strengthen arguments without writing for her. When she asks about her conclusion, it poses questions: "How does your ending connect to your thesis? What implications does your argument have for treatment approaches?" Her professor reviews the interaction logs, seeing genuine intellectual engagement rather than AI-generated content, satisfying their assessment integrity needs while recognizing Sarah's legitimate use of available tools.

The [submission phase](#) generates an "AI Use Report" that Sarah includes with her paper, showing her query patterns, time invested, and types of assistance received. This transparency addresses the institution's accountability requirements and her professor's need to understand

how AI was integrated into the work. The report shows Sarah spent 12 hours across multiple sessions, asked 47 questions, and revised her thesis three times based on Socratic dialogue (evidence of genuine learning process).

Throughout this journey, [tensions](#) may emerge between stakeholders. Sarah sometimes wishes for more direct assistance (or she wants Socratiq to write the essay entirely for her), especially when facing deadlines. Her professor appreciates the visibility but worries about becoming overly focused on surveillance rather than teaching. The institution values accountability but questions whether monitoring might discourage healthy experimentation with AI tools. Parents appreciate knowing their tuition supports genuine learning but wonder if such scaffolding is always necessary. These tensions also reflect broader questions about AI in education: How much assistance is too much? How do we balance efficiency with deep learning? Can we prepare students for an AI-integrated workforce while maintaining academic rigor? Socratiq doesn't eliminate these tensions but provides a framework for navigating them transparently. This allows each stakeholder to see how their values are being addressed while acknowledging the tradeoffs involved.

This user journey concludes with Sarah having produced [original work that was enhanced but not replaced by AI assistance](#). She's developed both domain knowledge and meta-cognitive skills about how to use AI tools effectively. Her professor can confidently assess her work, the institution maintains its academic standards, and Sarah is better prepared for a future where AI collaboration is the norm rather than the exception.